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Parents as customers, students as consumers: Exploring emotional rules and regulation strategies of academic tutors in China

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ABSTRACT

The emotional labor of academic tutors within the private tutoring sector remains under-researched compared to that of teachers in mainstream educational contexts. Within a for-profit educational service setting, tutors navigate a dual identity as both professional educators and front-line service providers. This study investigates the emotional rules and regulation strategies employed by 31 tutors, supplemented by perspectives from their managers and clients. Findings reveal that tutors operate under a "parents as customers, students as consumers" ethos, obliging them to follow two emotional rules: committing to efficient and engaging teaching with passion, and providing excellent service with heart and responsibility. In contrast to schoolteachers, tutors possess limited autonomy to genuinely express their emotions, leading them to rely on surface and deep acting, including disguising, ignoring, and self-persuading, to regulate their emotions. By highlighting the distinct emotional demands placed on tutors, this study illuminates the implications of emotional labor in commercial educational contexts and offers critical perspectives on the evolving nature of teaching under neoliberal reforms, as well as the dialectical interplay between the emotional labor landscapes of schoolteachers and tutors within a linked professional ecology.

1. Introduction

In the post-industrial service society, emotional labor has emerged as a crucial dimension of the workforce, operating alongside manual and intellectual labor. As such, Hochschild's (1983) theory of emotional labor provides a vital framework for analyzing labor relations within the service sector. Research in this area has expanded from front-line service roles to include care work and professional service occupations such as lawyers, teachers, and doctors (Gabriel et al., 2023; Wharton, 2009). Within the field of education, scholars have extensively investigated the multifaceted nature of teachers' emotional labor across diverse educational levels, subjects, disciplines, and cultural contexts, while also highlighting its divergence from that of typical service workers (Nazari & Karimpour, 2022; Stark & Bettini, 2021; Yin, 2016; Zembylas, 2005). However, despite these illuminating findings, the literature has predominantly focused on teaching staff within mainstream educational settings. Comparatively little attention has been directed toward academic tutors working in tutorial centers, also referred to as private tutoring or shadow education, a sector that has experienced substantial global growth in recent decades and has become a ubiquitous feature of educational landscapes in many

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countries (Bray, 2017).

Crucially, private tutoring represents not merely an under-studied context, but a critical case for understanding the evolving nature of teachers' emotional labor under market conditions. While marketization has reshaped relationships in formal schooling, the public-good nature of compulsory education imparts a hybrid character to that transformation. In contrast, private tutoring operates at the far end of the marketized education spectrum, offering an ideal setting to examine how purely market-driven logics reshape emotional demands. Moreover, its relevance is heightened for studies on interpersonal emotion regulation: unlike mainstream schooling, the private tutoring setting is characterized by a distinctive spatial and temporal co-presence of parents and students (Pan & Zhou, 2023). Within the shared physical and temporal boundaries of a tutorial session, tutors must regulate not only their own emotions but also dynamically navigate the affective states of both students and their parents, making this context particularly fitting for such inquiry.

A persistent debate within research on teachers' emotions concerns the extent to which their work constitutes emotional labor, a controversy primarily centered on Hochschild's (1983) defining criteria. Drawing on studies of flight attendants and bill collectors, Hochschild posits that emotional labor "is sold for a wage" (p. 7) and is characterized by three key elements: "First, they require face-to-face or voice-to-voice contact with the public. Second, they require the worker to produce an emotional state in another person—gratitude or fear, for example. Third, they allow the employer, through training and supervision, to exercise a degree of control over the emotional activities of employees" (p. 147). While researchers generally agree that teachers' work fulfills the first two criteria, the third has been a point of contention. Some scholars (e.g., Oplatka, 2007) contend that teachers' emotional management is not governed by a specific employer but is largely voluntary, suggesting that the external gains associated with emotional labor are incompatible with the ethical and moral dimensions of teaching, thereby challenging the applicability of Hochschild's framework.

In contrast, other researchers argue that the external control of teachers' emotions can be subtly embedded within ethical norms, cultural expectations, and professional standards (Winograd, 2003; Yin & Lee, 2012; Zembylas, 2002). This debate has been further complicated by the impact of neoliberal market-oriented reforms on education, which have reconfigured the nature and intensity of teachers' emotional labor (Hebson et al., 2007). However, a significant limitation of this discussion is its tendency to treat teachers as a homogeneous group, often overlooking potential variations between public and private educational settings. Moreover, it has largely neglected the experiences of academic tutors in tutorial centers, whose working conditions align more clearly with Hochschild's conception of emotional labor.

Unlike primary and secondary schooling, tutorial centers typically operate as profit-driven entities that provide educational products and services. Consequently, beyond the cultural expectations and professional norms shared with schoolteachers, tutors' emotional expressions are also subject to direct oversight and management by tutorial center owners. Tutors occupy a dual role as both educators and service providers (Pan, 2020; Pan et al., 2024), and their emotional labor thus embodies characteristics of both schoolteachers and front-line service workers. Examining the emotional labor of tutors can therefore yield valuable comparative insights into the emotional experiences of diverse teaching professionals, enriching the broader literature on teachers' emotions and emotional labor.

Against this backdrop, the present study investigates the emotional rules and regulation strategies employed by academic tutors in China. Through this analysis, we compare and discuss the emotional labor of tutors and schoolteachers—particularly those operating within neoliberal market-oriented environments—to illuminate broader patterns and variations in the emotional dimensions of educational work.

2. Literature review

2.1. Emotional labor, work and management

With her seminal study of flight attendants' work, Hochschild (1983) first developed the concept of emotional labor. Emotional labor, as defined by Hochschild (1983), refers to labor that "requires one to induce or suppress feeling in order to sustain the outward countenance that produces the proper state of mind in others" (p. 7). Hochschild distinguishes between emotional management in the private and public spheres. Emotional management in the private sphere is referred to as emotional work or also directly as emotional management, while in the public sphere, it is termed emotional labor. Emotional labor means the management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display. It is sold for a wage and therefore has exchange value. Emotional work refers to the same acts performed in private contexts where they have use value (Hochschild, 1983).

Since its introduction, emotional labor has been increasingly studied across various professions, leading to criticism and further development. Some researchers (e.g., Bolton, 2005; Bolton & Boyd, 2003) indicate that the criteria for defining emotional labor, distinguishing it from emotional work, is oversimplified by relying on a public-private dichotomy. They contend that Hochschild'

Table 1
A typology of emotion management (Bolton & Boyd, 2003).

	Pecuniary	Prescriptive	Presentational	Philanthropic
Feeling rules	Commercial	Professional Organisational	Social	Social
Associated motivations	Instrumental	Altruism Status Instrumental	Ontological Security Conformity	Gift

framework does not adequately differentiate "distinction between emotion work as part of the capitalist labour process, emotion work due to professional norms of conduct, or emotion work during normal social interaction in the workplace" (Bolton, 2005, p. 60). To capture this diversity, they introduced four conceptual types, rather than relying on the broad concept of emotional labor: pecuniary (emotional management according to commercial values), prescriptive (emotional management according to organizational/professional rules of conduct), presentational and philanthropic (emotional management according to general social feeling "rules") (Bolton, 2005; Bolton & Boyd, 2003). Table 1 presents the detailed descriptions of these concepts.

Grandey et al. (2013, p. 18) criticized the "original description of emotional labor implied a dichotomy of occupations," but it "may vary in degree across occupations and even across contexts within occupations." Thus, they prefer to conceptualize emotional labor as existing along a continuum ranging from "pure emotional labor" contexts on one end and "pure emotional work" contexts on the other end (Grandey et al., 2013). These categorizations and refinements provide a suitable scaffold for comparing the emotions of various groups in different professions and within the same profession, specifically, schoolteachers and academic tutors in the teaching profession.

2.2. Emotional rules, interpersonal emotion regulation and regulation strategies

Emotional rules and regulation strategies are central to the study of emotional labor. Emotional rules represent a form of organizational control, while workers employ regulation strategies to either comply with or resist these imposed expectations. Emotional rules, or "feeling rules" termed by Hochschild (1983), are "what guide emotion work by establishing the sense of entitlement or obligation that governs emotional exchanges" (p. 56). For teachers, such rules of emotional display and expression are rarely explicit but are embedded within ethical codes, professional techniques, and specialized pedagogical knowledge (Zembylas, 2002, 2005).

Despite the extensive literature on teachers' emotional labor, few empirical studies systematically summarize the emotional rules that govern their work. Winograd (2003) summarized five feeling rules through a one-year self-study, including teachers have affection and even love for their students; teachers show enthusiasm for subject matter as well as for students; teachers avoid overt displays of extreme emotions, especially anger and other dark emotions; teachers love their work; teachers have a sense of humor and laugh at their own mistakes as well as the peccadilloes of students. In the Chinese context, Yin and Lee (2012) found that teachers are expected to be both passionate and rational. They identified four emotional rules governing teachers' work: (1) commit to teaching with passion; (2) hide negative emotions; (3) maintain positive emotions; and (4) instrumentalize emotions to achieve teaching goals (Yin & Lee, 2012). Zhang et al. (2020) further identified three rules for Chinese preschool teachers' emotional expression: adept in emotional control; active use of emotion; and keep smiling service. Smiling service is a market-oriented emotional rule, which becomes even more salient for non-governmental preschool teachers where the pressure to survive market competition is intense.

Emotional rules define what are "appropriate" and "inappropriate" feelings (Zembylas, 2002), and their enactment fundamentally occurs within social interactions. This highlights the critical role of interpersonal emotion regulation—the processes through which individuals influence their own and others' emotions within social contexts (Niven et al., 2009; Niven, 2017; Zaki & Williams, 2013)—as a crucial bridge connecting organizational rules to individual regulatory strategies. It shifts the analytic focus from intrapersonal management to the dyadic and relational co-construction of emotional experiences (Barthel et al., 2018; Zaki & Williams, 2013). The importance of this shift is particularly pronounced in teaching. Given that the core activity involves constant interaction with students, teachers' roles extend beyond merely managing their internal states to comply with rules; they actively and strategically regulate students' emotions as a fundamental pedagogical practice (Keller & Becker, 2021; Sun & Yin, 2024). Through these daily interactions, abstract emotional rules are concretely applied, negotiated, and realized (Oplatka, 2007; Yin & Lee, 2012; Zembylas, 2005). Thus, interpersonal emotion regulation dynamically translates broad emotional rules into concrete, moment-to-moment emotional performances and experiences.

This dynamic underscores the necessity of emotion regulation to express institutionally expected emotions. Hochschild (1983) first proposed two strategies for emotion regulation, i.e., surface acting and deep acting. Surface acting refers to one merely changing how they outwardly appear, while deep acting means that the outward display is a natural result of inner work on feelings. In addition to surface and deep acting, Ashforth and Humphrey (1993) added the expression of genuine emotion or genuinely expressing as the third regulation strategy. Teacher are "more able to genuinely express negative emotions, as the target of the emotional labor, their students, are less mature and less powerful in classroom interactions" (Yin, 2016). Yin (2016) further delineated seven strategies among Chinese teachers: surface acting (pretending, restraining), deep acting (refocusing, reframing, and separating), and genuine expressing (releasing, outpouring). However, a reversal in the power relationship between tutors and their clients within the tutoring industry may render some of the teachers' regulation strategies ineffective for tutors.

2.3. Tutors' roles, identities and emotions

There has been a corresponding surge in research due to the rapid growth of private tutoring. Existing research on tutors highlights various aspects such as the differences between tutors and schoolteachers, the multiple roles and identities played by tutors, and the tutor-student and tutor-parent relationship. Tutors often exhibit personality traits that distinguish them from traditional schoolteachers. While schoolteachers may sometimes be perceived as humdrum or monotonous (Aurini, 2006), research suggests that tutors are typically portrayed as young, trendy, and even possess a celebrity-like aura (Koh, 2014; Yung & Yuan, 2020). Compared to schoolteachers, tutors typically have diverse roles and integrated identities. Their roles extend beyond those of simple teaching professionals, encompassing roles such as authoritative exam experts who can enhance student performance (Yung & Yuan, 2020), or elder siblings who provide support, academically and emotionally, like friends or older and more experienced peers (Hallsén &

Karlsson, 2019).

This multifaceted context often results in tutors forming closer, more personal relationships with their clients, including students and parents (Aurini, 2006; Gupta, 2022). The expectation for tutors to effectively address the needs of students and parents means that they are often viewed more as service providers rather than strictly professional educators (Pan et al., 2024). Consequently, the service-oriented nature of their work leads to increased workloads, extended working hours, blurred work-life boundaries, and a substantial amount of emotional labor that tutors must undertake (Pan & Zhou, 2023). Despite these challenges, existing literature lacks an in-depth exploration of the emotional rules that guide tutors' behavior and the strategies they employ to regulate their emotions. Therefore, the present study is structured around the following two questions:

1. What are the rules governing academic tutors' emotional labor in China?
2. What strategies do academic tutors use to regulate their emotions?

3. Methodology

3.1. Context

Private tutoring has become a global educational phenomenon, yet it is most firmly established in regions marked by intense academic competition and strong cultural emphasis on scholastic achievement, particularly within East Asia under the enduring influence of Confucian educational values (Bray, 2007). China stands at the epicenter of this industry, operating the world's largest private tutoring market and employing the highest number of tutors globally. According to statistics released by the Chinese Society of Education and the Ministry of Education, there were an estimated 7 to 8.5 million private tutors actively working in China in 2016, a figure that stands in striking comparison to the 11.87 million schoolteachers within the formal education system. This substantial ratio not only underscores the significance of the private tutoring sector but also establishes China as an ideal setting for comparative educational research, particularly in examining differences in emotional labor between tutors and conventional schoolteachers.

To capture the nuanced realities of this context, an ethnographic research design was implemented in Beijing between October 2019 and January 2020. Beijing was selected purposively due to its status as a major national hub for private tutoring enterprises. The city hosts a high concentration of diverse tutorial centers, ranging from large chains to small-scale initiatives, providing a rich and representative environment for examining the emotional dimensions of tutoring work.

At the time of data collection, China's tutoring industry was in a period of vigorous expansion, despite increasing regulatory oversight and the continuous introduction of new policies. However, an abrupt and unexpected turning point soon followed. In 2021, the Chinese government released the *Opinions on Further Reducing the Homework Burden and Off-campus Tutoring Burden of Students in Compulsory Education*, commonly known as the "double reduction" policy. Under this policy, the scale of China's tutoring industry shrank dramatically, and the number of tutors plummeted. Although official statistics are lacking, estimates from relevant studies suggest that the current number of tutors remains at approximately 3–5.5 million, with a slight rebound observed over the past two years. Based on our observations and related research, the core issues regarding tutors' working lives, professional identity and emotional labor have not undergone fundamental changes in the wake of the "double reduction" policy. Therefore, the findings of this study on the emotional rules and regulation strategies of tutors, as well as the comparisons made with schoolteachers, remain relevant and applicable in the post-"double reduction" context. Further implications and ongoing developments in the post-"double reduction" era will be examined in the conclusion and discussion section.

3.2. Data collection and analysis

This study employed a qualitative multi-method approach to gather comprehensive and triangulated data (Creswell & Poth, 2018; Yin, 2014). Primary methods included semi-structured interviews, observations, and document analysis. The core of the interview sample consisted of 31 tutors and three managerial staff recruited from 15 distinct private tutorial centers across Beijing. To incorporate multiple perspectives and enhance data validity, five parents were also interviewed. All interviews were conducted individually, face-to-face, in quiet settings conducive to open dialogue, with most sessions lasting between 1.5 to 2.5 h. All conversations were audio-recorded and later transcribed verbatim for analysis.

In selecting institutions and interviewees, we employed maximum variation sampling, a purposive sampling approach. "This approach consists of determining in advance some criteria that differentiate the sites or participants and then selecting sites or participants that are quite different on the criteria." (Creswell & Poth, 2018, p. 158) Guidance for categorization was drawn from the 2016 *Research Report on China's Primary and Secondary Schools' Extracurricular Tutoring Industry*, published by the Chinese Society of Education, which classifies tutorial centers into three main types: nationwide centers with annual revenues exceeding 2 billion RMB, regional centers with annual revenues between 100 million and 2 billion RMB, and local centers with annual revenues below 100 million RMB. This study includes cases from all three categories.

Recruitment of tutors followed a stratified sampling strategy to ensure diversity across key demographic and professional characteristics, including gender, highest education level, subject specialization, grade levels taught, and years of teaching experience. Specifically, potential participants were contacted through the first author's personal network. As a graduate from a normal university, the first author had access to a considerable number of alumni working in tutorial centers. Additionally, a snowball sampling approach was employed: interviewed tutors were informed about the types and specific requirements of tutors still needed for the study and were asked to assist in referring suitable candidates. Prior to participation, informed consent was obtained from all tutors, emphasizing that

their involvement was entirely voluntary. Data collection and analysis proceeded concurrently until no new information emerged, at which point theoretical saturation was considered achieved. The final tutor cohort comprised 17 female and 14 male participants. Their teaching experience ranged from 1 to 10 years, with a majority (54.8 %) having less than three years of experience. Twenty participants were recent university graduates, while the remainder had professional backgrounds either in public school teaching or other industries. A strategic purposive subsample of six tutors with previous experience in public schools was included to enable explicit comparison of emotional rules and regulation strategies across institutional contexts. In terms of highest educational qualification, 21 tutors held a bachelor's degree and 10 held a master's degree. For detailed information, please refer to Table 2.

To complement interview data, extensive observational fieldwork was conducted. Researchers visited each of the 15 tutorial centers to observe teaching sessions, tutor-student interactions, and parent-tutor communications. In particular, detailed observations were conducted for two complete tutorial sessions—one in Chinese and one in Mathematics—focusing on the arrangement and structure of the teaching content, the emotional atmosphere of the classroom, the tutor's instructional language and strategies, interactions among students, tutors, and parents, as well as the handling of any classroom conflicts. Detailed field notes were taken to record non-verbal behaviors, emotional expressions, physical settings, and relevant pedagogical practices. These observations provided valuable contextual data, helping to situate interview responses within actual practices and institutional environments.

The documents collected in this study encompass three main categories: government regulations on tutoring governance and tutor qualifications; institutional policies on tutor training, management, and performance evaluation; and tutors' personal documents such as lesson plans, teaching reflections, and written commentaries on the private tutoring sector. These materials provided critical insights into the structural and normative context of tutors' work, and helped triangulate findings from interviews and observations.

The data analysis process followed an ongoing, iterative cycle consistent with qualitative interpretive methodology, moving from broad descriptive coding toward more explanatory themes, as guided by the analytic framework of Miles and Huberman (1994). Transcripts, field notes, and documents were systematically coded. We employed a dual approach to coding, which was both inductive and theory-guided. Initially, we conducted open coding to identify recurring themes and patterns from the raw data, allowing categories to emerge organically. Subsequently, we refined and structured these codes by drawing upon the theoretical frameworks to ensure analytical rigor and coherence. Throughout the process, regular inter-coder discussions were held to resolve discrepancies, enhance consistency, and strengthen the validity of the coding scheme. Since "meaning and action are collectively negotiated and context-dependent", and "what people say is often a poor predictor of what they do," a triangulation strategy, as advocated by Jerolmack and Khan (2014), was rigorously applied by comparing and cross-referencing evidence from interviews, observations, and documents. This multi-source approach strengthened the validity of the findings. Strict confidentiality was maintained throughout the research process; all identifiers were removed and pseudonyms were assigned to all participants and institutions. Specifically, tutor surnames were assigned in the order of interviews based on the sequence of the *Hundred Family Surnames* (*Bai Jia Xing*), and do not

Table 2
Demographic information of interviewed tutors.

Name	Degree	Teaching subject(s)	Years of teaching in tutorial centers	Year(s) of teaching in public schools (if any)
Mr. He	Master	English	5	NA
Mr. Hua	Bachelor	Chinese	9	NA
Mr. Jiang	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Mr. Jin	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Kong	Master	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Lyu	Bachelor	Math, Physics and Chemistry	2	NA
Mr. Sun	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Tao	Master	English	7	NA
Mr. Wei (卫)	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Mr. Xu	Bachelor	Mathematics	10	1
Mr. Yan	Bachelor	Mathematics	7	1
Mr. You	Bachelor	Physics	4	NA
Mr. Zhang	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Mr. Zhou	Bachelor	Physics	3	NA
Ms. Cao	Master	English	2	NA
Ms. Chen	Master	History	4	NA
Ms. Chu	Bachelor	English	6	NA
Ms. Feng	Bachelor	Chinese	3	8
Ms. Han	Master	English	4	8
Ms. Li	Bachelor	Mathematics	8	NA
Ms. Qian	Master	Politics	3	NA
Ms. Qin	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Ms. Shen	Master	Physics	1	NA
Ms. Shi	Bachelor	Chinese	5	6
Ms. Wang	Bachelor	Chinese	1	4
Ms. Wei (魏)	Bachelor	Mathematics	2	NA
Ms. Wu	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Ms. Yang	Bachelor	English	8	NA
Ms. Zhao	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Ms. Zheng	Bachelor	Mathematics	5	NA
Ms. Zhu	Bachelor	English	4	NA

reflect their real surnames. Institutional names were assigned fictitiously using the names of planets.

Regarding the researchers' personal backgrounds, none of us has ever worked, either full-time or part-time, at a tutorial center. Our connection to the field stems from observing many classmates and friends pursue careers in tutoring industry after graduation, which has continually drawn our attention to this professional community and the broader educational issues it involves. This ongoing exposure ultimately inspired the research interest motivating the present study. Our position as outsiders allows us to approach the subject with greater neutrality and to minimize potential biases, thereby enhancing the trustworthiness of the study—a particularly important consideration given the sensitive and commercialized nature of private tutoring.

4. Findings

Venus, one of China's largest tutorial centers, served as a key source of participants for this study, with five tutors interviewed from the institution. In September 2019, Venus introduced a unified brand tagline: "Venus Good Tutors." This slogan encapsulates the three core qualities the company expects of its tutors: profound academic knowledge, joyful and motivational teaching, and excellent service with heart and responsibility. The tagline is highly representative of the broader expectations within China's tutoring industry, emphasizing two fundamental attributes: the ability to teach in an engaging and inspiring manner, and a strong service orientation. Joyful and motivational teaching underscores the importance of tutors being passionate about their work, creating engaging and intriguing learning experiences for their students. Excellent service extends the tutor's role beyond instruction, requiring attentiveness to the needs of both parents and students.

Operating within a market-driven service sector, the tutoring industry adheres to the principle that "the customer is God." This commercial context redefines the relationship between tutors and their clients, transcending a mere teaching relationship (tutors as professional educators) while evolving into a service-oriented relationship (tutors as service providers). A prevalent industry perspective treats parents as customers (the payers) and students as consumers (the end users), significantly reshaping tutors' work dynamics, professional identities, and the emotional rules and strategies they must navigate.

4.1. Emotional rules

4.1.1. Commit to efficient and engaging teaching with passion

In a highly competitive environment, tutoring providers are seen as complementary commercial organizations; they do not have a consistent source of students as public schools do, whether based on location or other factors. Thus, they must rely on personal and institutional qualities to attract customers and ensure survival. In this context, emotion becomes a particularly useful and convenient tool. Since parents (or grandparents) and students are typically co-present during private tutoring sessions, creating a satisfying emotional environment for both parties within this triadic interaction emerges as a key institutional strategy. Consequently, private tutoring involves significantly more emotional labor than formal schooling.

To distinguish themselves, tutorial centers must compete on the quality of instruction and personnel. Regarding teaching, this competitive pressure requires tutors to avoid the stereotypically "boring" styles sometimes associated with public school teachers (Kennedy, 2005). Instead, they are expected to exhibit unique charisma, passion, and innovative pedagogical methods. In our interviews, many tutors emphasized the importance of passion and positive tutor-student interaction in this setting. Mr. Sun, a mathematics tutor, recalled his impression during an internship:

> During my internship, I served as a teaching assistant for several tutors. The classroom atmosphere and the tutors' passion left a deep impression on me. It was the first time I realized that lessons could be taught in such an engaging way. This stood in stark contrast to the university courses I had taken, where very few teachers demonstrated that level of passion and taught in such a dynamic manner.

The display of passion in teaching serves a dual function. On one hand, it is a prescriptive professional requirement rooted in pedagogical ethics. Passionate teaching and positive interaction can enhance learning efficiency, motivate students, and ultimately improve academic performance (Abuhassna et al., 2021, 2023; Mustapha et al., 2023; Yin & Lee, 2012). On the other hand, it fulfills a pecuniary commercial need, meeting parental expectations for private tutoring. In interviews, parents expressed a preference for young, energetic tutors who interact well with children, as opposed to what they perceive as ill-tempered, dull, or indifferent teachers in traditional public schools.

> If you have a bad temper, you won't be gentle with my child … You would bring that negativity into the classroom and to my child … [The tutors hired by tutorial centers, often in their 20 s or 30 s,] are lively and cheerful, and their teaching and interaction styles are excellent. (Ms. Dou, mother)

Besides passion, teaching provided by tutorial centers is characterized by two salient features: efficiency and engagement. Public school teaching has long been criticized for inefficiency. Numerous reform policies, especially those shaped by neoliberal principles, have aimed to improve the effectiveness and efficiency of public education (Ambrosio, 2013). In contrast, tutorial centers, as for-profit organizations, are often perceived as more efficient. Their advertisements consistently highlight the ability to help students achieve high scores in the shortest time possible, placing significant demands on tutors. As Mr. Jiang, a tutorial center manager, explained: "You're required to teach in the fastest and most efficient way—to convey key points and logical structures clearly and succinctly, making them as easy as possible for students to grasp." This pursuit of efficiency resembles the concept of McDonaldization, which aims to transition customers from hunger to full in the minimal amount of time (Ritzer, 2015). Similarly, tutoring efficiency focuses on

enabling students to master knowledge points rapidly and improve their academic performance in the shortest time possible.

Engagement, meanwhile, reflects a deliberate shift away from the often monotonous and conventional teaching methods typical of mainstream education. Mr. Xie, the founder of a tutorial center chain, observed: "Nowadays, parents have high expectations of tutorial centers. They demand both process and results. Tutorial centers need to function as both 'hospitals' and 'restaurants.'" The "hospital" role emphasizes achieving tangible academic outcomes, while the "restaurant" aspect focuses on providing an enjoyable and engaging learning experience. Consequently, tutorial centers feel compelled to make their lessons dynamic and entertaining. However, sustaining such a high-energy classroom environment imposes considerable emotional and professional strain on tutors. Furthermore, an overemphasis on entertainment may risk compromising instructional rigor and professionalism of instruction. As Ms. Feng, a Chinese tutor, remarked:

> Sometimes the salesperson would tell me that I needed to make the class really fun. "You have to crack jokes. Kids love listening to them, and parents will be more likely to renew the payment." Then I thought to myself, maybe they should just go listen to crosstalk (*xiangsheng*) instead. What kind of Chinese class is this supposed to be, anyway? How am I supposed to come up with so many jokes to tell them? … I feel like it really takes away from the actual teaching content.

Ms. Feng's perspective highlights the inherent tension and struggle tutors experience in balancing prescriptive emotional management and pecuniary emotional management. While tutorial centers may prioritize profitability, often advocating for highly entertaining and emotionally charged teaching styles to satisfy clients and secure renewals, tutors themselves must navigate and negotiate these competing expectations. They strive to maintain educational integrity and professional authenticity while simultaneously fulfilling the market-oriented emotional performance required by their roles. This means that they need to balance emotional work and emotional labor.

4.1.2. Provide excellent service with heart and responsibility

In the tutoring industry, a common saying reflects a prevailing belief: "If you cannot teach well, service can compensate" (*jiaoxue bu zu, fuwu lai cou*). This notion suggests that by focusing on providing high levels of service, tutors can enhance parents' and students' satisfaction levels, thereby boosting overall performance, particularly when their teaching skills and effectiveness alone may be inadequate (Pan et al., 2024).

> If the children' academic performance is poor, but you want to secure continued enrollment, you have to rely on service. You need to compensate for weak teaching with strong service. You can struggle through the service work since some children simply cannot improve their grades in a short period. (Ms. Zhao, Chinese)

Therefore, "providing excellent service with heart and responsibility" has emerged as a key emotional rule, complementing "committing to efficient and engaging teaching with passion." This echoes the expectations imposed on typical service industry personnel. Compared to schoolteachers, tutors in tutorial centers undertake more service-oriented tasks, and thus the "service providers" in their identity besides professional educators. Ms. Wu, both a manager and a Chinese tutor, articulated this clearly:

> I see tutorial centers as a business model, not a public service. I'm here to earn money. Tutorial centers are corporations … A good educator, if limited to tutors [rather than schoolteachers], that is, coupled with the characteristics of tutorial centers—a certain nature of service. You must be able to make the service better.

This rule focuses on the requirement for tutorial centers and tutors to address a wide range of academic and affective needs of students and parents (Gupta, 2022). In the public school system, limited educational resources and low teacher-student ratios make it difficult for schoolteachers to attend to every student. Students' affective and emotional needs can rarely be fully met inside schools (Pan et al., 2024). Yet children need individual attention which is beyond what traditional mass education can provide in an increasingly personalized society (Hallsén & Karlsson, 2019). While improved academic performance is a primary objective, some parents and students seek tutoring services for the empathetic and attentive support they provide. Consequently, tutors often strive to accommodate diverse parental and student requests, sometimes avoiding direct opposition to maintain client satisfaction. Parents are often conscious of this power dynamic, as illustrated by Ms. Dou's candid remark during an interview: "Money talks … Because they earn money from me, of course they wouldn't dare offend me." This highlights a potential power imbalance inherent in the tutor-client relationship.

For tutors, in practice, such services and interpersonal emotional interactions include motivating disengaged students, comforting anxious parents, and maintaining a positive demeanor, among others. Among students attending tutoring, some are academically struggling. This academic underperformance is often accompanied by corresponding emotional issues, psychological pressures, and even conflicts between students and parents. Tutors must invest considerable effort and patience to encourage students emotionally and address related problems. Besides students, parents may also have associated issues that need attention. Within China's highly competitive educational environment, parents sometimes exhibit excessive anxiety, which places significant pressure on tutors. Consequently, tutors are often compelled not only to attend to the emotional needs of their students but also to reassure anxious parents and help alleviate their concerns.

> I don't really enjoy communicating with parents that much … They tend to get overly anxious … When parents are especially anxious, it puts a lot of pressure on me. Whenever I talk to parents, the pressure just comes immediately—it really is quite stressful, yeah. (Ms. Chen, history)

Different from formal school education, the business model of private tutoring endows the attentive service provided by tutors with

a distinctly hybrid character: partly driven by professional ethics and requirements, and partly by commercial motives to satisfy and retain clients—with the latter often taking precedence in practice. Therefore, the tutor's role aligns more closely with emotional labor than with emotional work. Tutors must establish a close connection, almost salespeople-client relationship with parents and students. Their responsibilities extend beyond instruction to include cultivating student interest in subjects, promoting good study habits, designing customized learning plans, and offering emotional and developmental support. Additionally, tutors are mandated to maintain regular communication with parents, provide feedback on students' performance and progress, encourage course renewals, and even promote other programs offered by the center. This approach mirrors the caring ethic of schoolteachers while simultaneously embodying a commercial nature aimed at maximizing the tutorial center's profitability. Thus, it incorporates a blend of pecuniary and prescriptive emotional management, as described by Ms. Feng:

> In corporate meetings, service is constantly emphasized. Service needs to be good. Good service drives renewal. Where do you get your renewal number from? From the service. Even if your teaching is mediocre, as long as you serve [the clients] well, you will get rewarded.

Engaging in a large amount of service work and emotional labor exposes tutors to heavy workloads and negative emotions, rendering them susceptible to emotional exhaustion and burnout. As tutors perform their service duties, they often adopt a role more akin to that of front-line service providers rather than professional educators. Despite this circumstance, their self-perception typically aligns more closely with the identity of professional educators rather than service providers. This discrepancy can cause internal conflict, as expressed by Mr. Zhou, a physics tutor: "The service work makes me feel negative. Just tedious, right? Sometimes I feel that it is not the thing I should do as an educator. That really brings me down."

For tutorial centers, tutors are akin to a disposable product and a turnover profession (Abbott, 2001). As a result, reducing tutor burnout is rarely an organizational priority. Ms. Chen, a history tutor, described the industry as one where emotion regulation is crucial for longevity, stating, "You have to be exceptionally good at regulating your emotions if you want to last in this industry."

4.2. Regulation strategies

Tutors are more likely to use strategies of surface and deep acting to manage their emotions. These strategies primarily include the techniques of disguising, ignoring, and self-persuading. The most noticeable disparity between schoolteachers and tutors regarding regulation strategies is that tutors have little opportunity to genuinely express their emotions, whether releasing or outpouring. They have to repress their real emotions, especially when they are negative. As Ms. Feng noted: "At the center, I've been repressing myself as much as I can. I'm definitely not allowed to get angry." This observation aligns with previous studies on schoolteachers' management of negative emotions (e.g., Winograd, 2003; Yin & Lee, 2012), though tutors operate under more stringent emotional constraints.

4.2.1. Disguising

Disguising is a prevalent surface acting technique. It involves presenting emotions that are not genuinely felt, often through deliberately displaying false outward expressions. While both schoolteachers and tutors use this technique, the emotions they feign tend to differ. For instance, schoolteachers more often disguise a serious, unapproachable emotion, whereas tutors need to exhibit a positive, light-hearted, and lively emotion. Mr. Xu, a mathematics tutor and former public school teacher, illustrated this contrast:

> When I was in public school, I basically didn't show my smiling face and dared not to show it. With so many students, you have to stay serious … You need to maintain a stern expression to make students respect and fear you. But that's not necessary in tutorial centers.

This aligns with the "keep smiling service" observed among non-governmental preschool teachers in Zhang et al.'s (2020) study. The key distinction lies in the context: as a purely market-driven organization, tutorial centers place greater emphasis on such smiling service and the cheerful, relaxed emotional atmosphere tutors cultivate—making it a more prominent and explicit feature in their teaching environments.

Negative and serious emotions, as discussed by Yin (2016), enable schoolteachers to appear "mysterious'' or even threatening. Keeping a distance from students helps protect the teachers' position within the teacher-student interaction. In contrast to this model, the tutor-student relationship in tutorial centers is often characterized by a greater sense of equality and intimacy. Tutors, operating within a context where parental and student expectations take precedence, find it difficult to maintain a deliberate distance or strict hierarchical structure in their interactions. Instead, they are often compelled to establish a close rapport with students and their parents to effectively address their specific needs (Aurini, 2006). This dynamic is reflected in interviews where tutors frequently describe their relationships with students as embodying a blend of "teacher and friend." Achieving such a type of relationship is comparatively challenging within the traditional Chinese public school system, which typically emphasizes teacher authority. Furthermore, given the generally younger age of tutors, some develop more informal, sibling-like relationships with their students. This observation resonates with existing research (e.g., Hallsén & Karlsson, 2019), which highlights the prevalence of less formal and more egalitarian tutor-student interactions in alternative educational settings.

> During class, I position myself as an educator. After class, I prefer to be like an older brother. I want to build a close relationship with them, not keep a strict tutor-student dynamic. (Mr. Jin, mathematics)

4.2.2. Ignoring

Ignoring means that tutors deliberately overlook some unexpected incidents that interfere with, and may negatively influence, their feelings and the teaching process (Yin, 2016). It is considered a form of deep acting. During classroom observations, we noted that most tutorial centers displayed specific "classroom norms" or "classroom reminders" in the hallways and classrooms, characterizing the expected behaviors of students and parents. These "norms" and "reminders" clearly state rules such as "please mute mobile phones," "please do not make noise and play," "please do not take photos and videos," and "please do not walk around." However, we observed some parents and students openly disregarding these guidelines. For instance, some parents or grandparents would record class content to facilitate their children's review in case they missed certain points during the lesson. Regarding such behaviors, tutors were more likely to adopt a neglectful approach while ignoring the infractions without intervening. In cases where intervention did occur, it tends to be limited.

This approach may appear to reflect the tutors' inability to effectively conduct classroom management, which sometimes leads to the disruption of teaching. In interviews with parents, some criticized this circumstance, arguing that the order in tutorial centers was not as good as the relatively strict classroom management in traditional schooling. They pointed out that even more unruly children could negatively influence their own children's learning. Ms. Zou, a mother, said:

> We especially prefer tutors who maintain better classroom order … the management and atmosphere matter. That is, the tutor's presence should be strong. They should tell noisy students to "shut up." I've seen some tutors at Mercury Company who are too timid to discipline students.

Our observations confirmed the presence of this phenomenon. From the tutors' perspective, however, they often feel limited in their authority and thus helpless in addressing these challenges. This is evident in the following interview excerpt:

> If I were a public school teacher, I would have a hundred ways to deal with misbehaving children. But as a tutor, I might just glance at them or say a word or two. There is no need to do more. If I push too hard, the student or parent will be unhappy or unsatisfied. Why create problems for myself? (Mr. Jiang, Chinese)

Mr. Jiang's words reveal how the presence of parents constrains the regulation strategies available to tutors. With parents co-present, tutors must consider parental perceptions and receptiveness when managing students. This necessitates maintaining an atmosphere acceptable to both parties, making overly strict discipline difficult to implement. Consequently, ignoring minor disruptions becomes a common approach, resulting in a relatively more relaxed classroom environment. This stands in contrast to the traditional Chinese emphasis on order and discipline, yet some tutors view the atmosphere in tutorial centers as more natural and humane.

> It's more relaxed here. For example, sometimes students eat during class. I might ask what they're doing, and they say they're really hungry. It feels especially laid-back. (Ms. Feng, Chinese)

4.2.3. Self-persuading

Self-persuading is also one of the most common emotion regulation strategies used by tutors, which belongs to deep acting. This strategy involves tutors reinterpreting and adjusting their emotional states and inner feelings to align with their external expressions. Given that negative emotions primarily arise from the service work rather than teaching, the ability to rationalize the service work and potential negative emotions becomes a crucial aspect of tutors' emotion regulation process. The primary self-persuasive logic frequently employed by tutors revolves around the aspect of more income. Tutors often justify their higher earnings compared to schoolteachers by emphasizing the additional service work and the corresponding emotional challenges they must undertake alongside teaching responsibilities. They believe that the relatively higher income they receive factors in an allowance for the service work and any negative emotions it may entail.

> I think it's quite normal. You get more income as a result … It's a fair trade. I do this [work], so I get this [money]. If I didn't, I wouldn't. It is a straightforward logic! (Ms. Wu, Chinese)

Ms. Yang, a center manager and senior English tutor, echoed this: "You can choose not to do the service work, but then you won't receive the related performance income."

Another important logic of the tutors' self-persuasion lies in their positioning as ordinary service industry employees rather than professional educators like schoolteachers. This shift in self-perception helps tutors normalize negative emotions encountered during service tasks. By adopting this perspective, tutors can effectively reduce internal stress and negative emotions resulting from conflicting identities. Consequently, they achieve internal consistency. Ms. Feng, who switched jobs from a public school to a tutorial center, shared:

> How do I put it? Tutors in tutorial centers have a stronger service role. That is, you're not just an educator. You're a service provider. You have to serve them well. When I first came here, I told a close colleague that I felt I was giving up my dignity as a teacher. Now I am a service provider, a service provider in the guise of an educator.

5. Conclusion and discussion

This study provided an in-depth examination of the emotional rules and regulation strategies employed by academic tutors working within tutorial centers in Beijing, China. By situating this investigation within the broader theoretical discourse surrounding emotional

labor, particularly the ongoing debate about whether teaching constitutes emotional labor or emotional work, this research illuminates the complex emotional landscape navigated by tutors operating in a distinctly market-oriented educational context. The for-profit nature of the tutoring system introduces unique emotional demands and constraints that significantly differentiate tutors' experiences from those of their counterparts in mainstream schooling.

A central finding of this study concerns the fundamental power dynamic that structures tutor-student-parent relationships. Unlike traditional educational environments where students are typically assigned to teachers and institutions, the tutorial center context positions students and parents as active consumers who exercise significant choice in selecting tutors and programs. This consumer-provider relationship creates a distinctive emotional economy where tutors must continually demonstrate positive and "appropriate" emotions across both teaching and service interactions. These emotional performances are strategically deployed to cultivate supportive learning environments and sustain strong relational bonds with students and parents. However, this constant emotional labor exacts a considerable psychological toll, manifesting in increased stress levels, emotional exhaustion, professional burnout, and ultimately contributing to the high turnover rates observed within the industry.

The research identifies two primary emotional rules that govern tutors' professional practice: first, the imperative to commit to efficient and engaging teaching with passion; second, the requirement to provide excellent service with heart and responsibility. Passion relates to the act of teaching itself—emphasizing how it is carried out with enthusiasm and effectiveness. Heart, on the other hand, focuses on the recipient and the relational quality of the service, characterized by care and accountability. Together, they form a unified set of emotional rules, akin to two sides of the same coin. While schoolteachers similarly face expectations of passion and care in their work, the tutoring context infuses these expectations with distinct market logic. Tutors must not only demonstrate pedagogical competence but also ensure that their teaching maintains student engagement and parent satisfaction to facilitate course renewals and institutional profitability. This commercial dimension transforms the nature of emotional responsibility, blending professional ethics with market imperatives to create a hybrid identity that merges educator and service provider.

Regarding emotion regulation strategies, tutors predominantly rely on three core approaches: disguising, ignoring, and self-persuading. This repertoire appears notably narrower than the seven strategies identified by Yin (2016) among Chinese schoolteachers, a discrepancy that reflects the distinct power dynamics characterizing the tutoring context. The consumer-provider relationship significantly constrains tutors' capacity for genuine emotional expression, particularly limiting strategies that involve emotional release or outpouring. The strategy of self-persuasion proves particularly revealing, as tutors attempt to reconcile their professional identity with commercial demands through various cognitive reframing techniques. Some emphasize their relatively higher compensation as justification for enduring emotionally challenging service work, while others attempt to re-conceptualize their professional identity from "educator" to "service provider" to reduce cognitive dissonance. However, these adjustments often remain incomplete, leaving many tutors experiencing persistent identity conflict and emotional strain.

The findings reveal significant differences between the emotional climates of tutoring and formal schooling. These differences are largely determined by distinct patterns of interpersonal interaction. Hargreaves (2000; 2001a; 2001b), in analyzing the emotional geographies of teaching, distinguished interactions across multiple distinct levels: teacher-student, teacher-parent, teacher-colleague, and teacher-administrator. In stark contrast, tutors frequently do not interact with parents and students separately. Instead, they engage with a community of customers and consumers comprised jointly of parents and students, as illustrated in Fig. 1. This distinct mode of interpersonal interaction underpins the substantial differences in the emotional rules and regulation strategies between schoolteachers and tutors.

Simultaneously, the findings must be understood within the broader context of neoliberal educational reforms that have transformed global educational landscapes over recent decades. The neoliberal paradigm conceptualizes education through an economic lens, emphasizing efficiency, accountability, and market competitiveness above other educational values (Davies & Bansel, 2007;

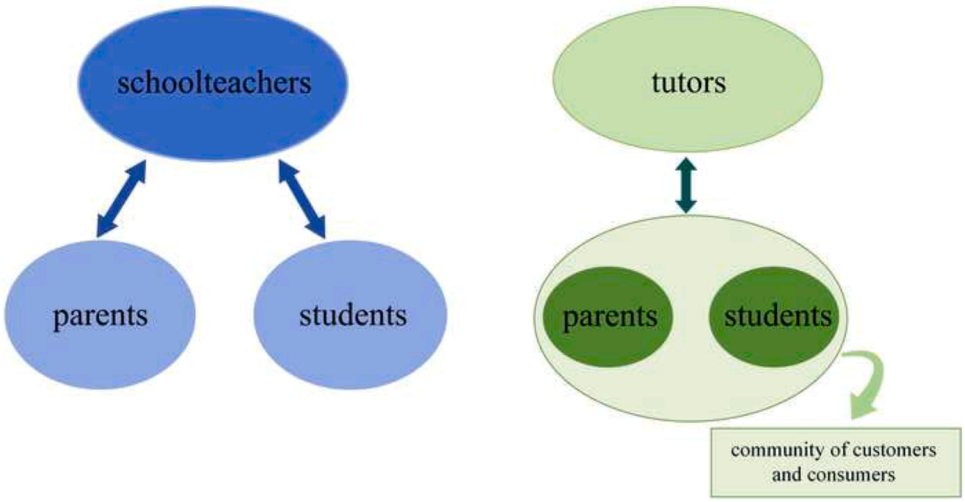

Fig. 1. A comparison of interpersonal interaction in schooling versus tutoring.

Hursh & Martina, 2003). Within this framework, teachers are reconceptualized as educational entrepreneurs and providers of educational products and services (Ball, 2003, 2016), with their work mirroring that of front-line service workers. This shift has progressively blurred the boundaries between professional ethos and commercial logic, moving teaching from emotional work and prescriptive emotional management toward emotional labor and pecuniary emotional management. The emotional experiences of tutors thus offer a revealing glimpse into the potential future of teaching emotions more broadly, as market logic continues to penetrate educational systems worldwide. Synthesizing Bolton's conceptual types with Grandey's continuum, Fig. 2 presents a comparative analysis of the emotional characteristics exhibited by tutors versus schoolteachers in the era of neoliberal market-oriented reform. This comparison raises crucial questions about the future trajectory of teachers' emotions: as marketization intensifies, will schoolteachers' emotional rules and regulation strategies increasingly converge with those of tutors? The emotional experiences of tutors suggest that the penetration of market logic into education may fundamentally reshape how teachers understand and manage their emotions, with significant implications for professional identity, emotional well-being, and educational quality. Thus, the significance of this study extends beyond the immediate context of tutoring industry to offer critical insights into the evolving nature of emotional labor across educational settings.

Furthermore, the tutoring sector itself is undergoing transformation and, in turn, influencing the emotional labor of schoolteachers. The rise of tutoring has, to some extent, filled the gap between school education and family education, precisely meeting and aligning with the needs of parents and students. Tutorial centers and their tutors have partially assumed or performed some of the roles and responsibilities that parents, schools, and teachers would otherwise need to fulfill. However, driven by profit motives, excessive marketization has led to corresponding problems. The "double reduction" policy implemented from 2021 onwards was partly motivated by the perception that the excessive marketization of tutoring fueled unnecessary educational anxiety and intensified academic competition. Consequently, the policy stringently curbed the market-driven expansion of tutoring, aiming to steer the sector towards emphasizing pedagogical substance over commercial tendencies. Theoretically, this shift could prompt tutorial center managers to recognize the roles of their institutions and tutors as part of the educational enterprise and as educators, respectively, rather than merely as commercial ventures. From a policy perspective, a crucial next step involves implementing measures to alleviate the pressure, anxiety, and burnout experienced by tutors due to excessive emotional labor. Specifically, this could include adjusting evaluation practices to balance commercial metrics—such as course renewal rates—with indicators of pedagogical quality and tutor well-being. Additionally, supporting tutors' emotional health through structured mentoring programs, dedicated spaces for peer

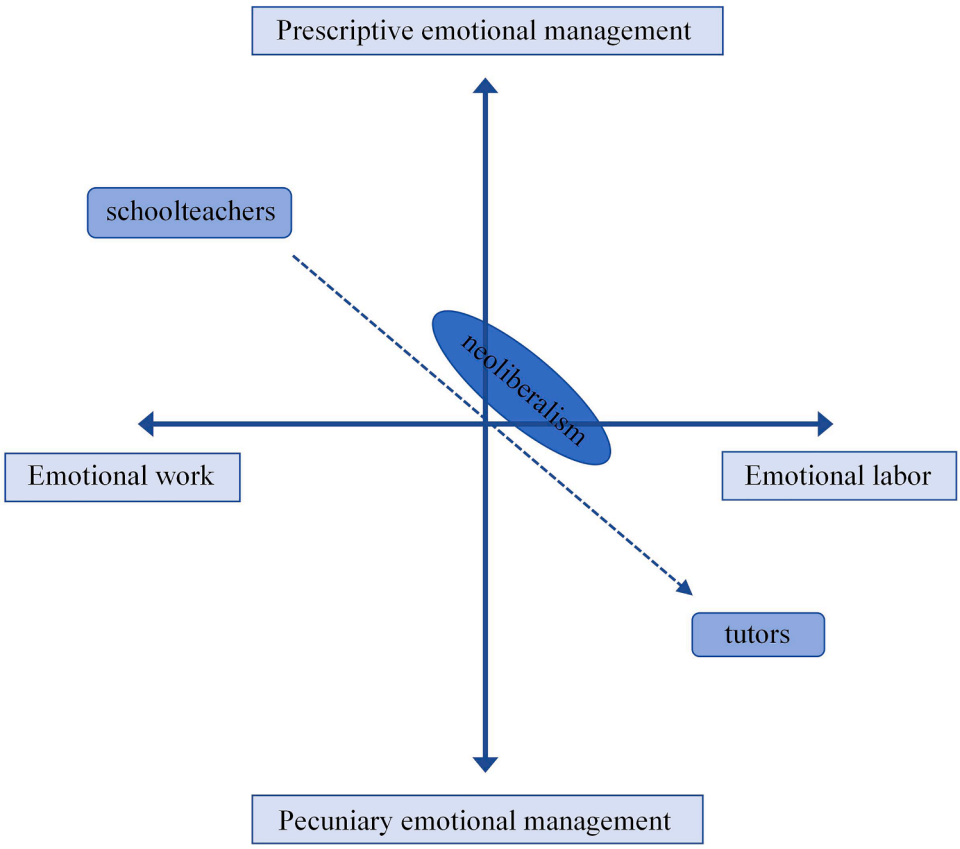

Fig. 2. A comparative analysis of the emotional characteristics exhibited by tutors versus schoolteachers in the era of neoliberal market-oriented reform.

debriefing on emotional challenges, and training in sustainable emotion regulation strategies would contribute to a healthier, more sustainable professional environment.

Concurrently, a notable consequence of the "double reduction" policy is the mandated provision of after-school programs by public schools. This effectively reallocates a significant portion of the academic and custodial responsibilities long borne by tutorial centers and their tutors back to schools and their teachers (Pan & Zhou, 2023). This has resulted in extended working hours, increased workload pressure, and the additional burden of emotional labor for schoolteachers during after-school program periods. Therefore, the emotional labor landscapes of schoolteachers and tutors exist in a dialectical relationship, simultaneously complementary and mutually constitutive within a linked professional ecology (Abbott, 2016).

This study is limited by its cross-sectional design, which fails to adequately address the longitudinal evolution of emotional labor, as well as comparative analyses across tutorial centers of varying scales and among tutors with different demographic backgrounds. These shortcomings present clear avenues for future investigation. Subsequent research could employ longitudinal methods to trace developmental trajectories, conduct systematic comparisons across diverse organizational and personal contexts, and further explore the interdependent relationship between the emotional labor of schoolteachers and tutors within the broader educational ecology.

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Dongdong Pan: Writing – original draft, Formal analysis. **Yisu Zhou:** Supervision, Conceptualization. **Kwok Kuen Tsang:** Writing – review & editing.

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